

## The Beekeeper's Daughter

Hannah Burgess grew up in her family's commercial beekeeping business, founded by her grandfather William Perry in northeast Pennsylvania in the 1950s, but she didn't envision herself as a beekeeper. If anything, she was a bit embarrassed to be known as the "beekeeper's daughter," and she was deathly allergic to bee stings.

Burgess attended cosmetology school and was working as a hairstylist in Florida when she started thinking about making skincare products using her family's honey. In 2010, she heard that demand for raw honey was surging, as consumers were embracing its reported health benefits.

The family business, Perry Apiaries, had always sold the honey from their thousands of hives to bigger companies, where it was processed and filtered before landing on grocery store shelves. Hannah decided to try selling it herself, as unfiltered raw honey.

"I thought, I'm just going to go for it," she said. "I took some honey and started bottling it, putting my own label on it and packaging it. I went to farmers' markets, and at the first farmers' market, I sold everything I had. I knew I had something good." (Leighton 2023)

The Beekeeper's Daughter was born, and by 2024, Burgess was using thousands of pounds of the family's honey harvest each year to produce and sell raw honey, honeycomb, and a variety of honey-based products like honey sticks, beeswax candles, and honey-sweetened soft drinks from her 6,000-square-foot warehouse and storefront in Plains, Pennsylvania.

### Background

Humans have used honey for centuries. The first honey came from wild bees, and the Egyptians began domesticating bees for honey production around 2400 BCE. Honey has long had religious and medicinal uses—as a food of the gods in Greece, an offering in Hindu texts, a preservative for Roman foods, and a prescription for wound healing in Hippocrates' time. (Bujor 2019)

Although Perry Apiaries started in the 1950s, Burgess's family history with honey dates back even earlier to the 1800s. Her ancestors in rural Pennsylvania started beekeeping as a hobby, maintaining colonies of bees that pollinated trees, flowers, plants, and crops in the area, including wildflowers and locust blossoms.

Burgess's grandfather studied beekeeping at Pennsylvania State University and transformed the family operation into a commercial beekeeping business. He began transporting the bees by refrigerated tractor-trailer to Florida each winter, where they could pollinate orange groves, saw palmetto, and Brazilian pepper. The different flowers result in different varieties of honey, each with its own color and taste.

In its natural state, honey includes pollen from the plants where the bees feed. However, most large commercial honey producers ultra-filter their honey—heating it, flash-cooling it, and

straining it—to remove the pollen, which helps stop the honey from crystallizing (changing from a smooth liquid to semi-solid). Processing also gives honey a milder, more consistent flavor, less affected by the specific floral landscapes.

### The Value Proposition



**Figure 1. Honey label with floral design**

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Burgess was committed to marketing a different kind of honey and honey products. She launched her private-label honey business in collaboration with her dad's beekeeping business and employed both her mom and her brother. She designed her honey labels to incorporate a floral pattern she saw on her great-grandfather's packaging (Figure 1). She marketed first to local communities, and continued to sell at farmers' markets even as the business expanded.

Although she automated parts of the process, like capping and labeling, to keep up with customer demand, the family kept bottling the honey by hand. The Beekeeper's Daughter honey had just one ingredient—honey—and she knew exactly where each drop came from, exactly which flowers her bees had been pollinating, whether orange blossoms, buckwheat, or saw palmetto. She labeled the jars accordingly (Figure 2).



**Figure 2. Beekeeper's Daughter's honey varieties.**

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Her raw honey was more likely to crystallize than many grocery store brands, but that's a risk she was willing to take. "You can just tell by the smell of it, you can tell by the taste of it," she said.

"Everybody's usually like, 'Oh, that's really, really good.'"

Burgess's role in the company has evolved from personally bottling the product out of a five-gallon

bucket in a garage to managing accounts, communicating with customers, packing online orders, and overseeing a business that produces thousands of pounds of honey annually. Beekeeper's Daughter (now also called BKD) honey is stocked in Wegmans Food Markets, a large grocery chain, as well as many stores and farmers' markets in Pennsylvania and Florida, in addition to various e-commerce platforms.

But for Burgess, family and community are still a key part of the value proposition. Customers routinely ask her if she is, in fact, the beekeeper's daughter—"the name is kind of cheesy," she

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says—but now she embraces that moniker. “Now I own it. This is what my family does, and it’s incredible.”

*Hannah Burgess was interviewed in 2024 by a College Board case author for this case study.*

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